

“ THIS IS NOT HOW MARATHI PEOPLE BEHAVE. RAJ THACKERAY IS PROMOTING HIS POLITICAL CAREER BY USING VIOLENCE. ”

M. N. SINGH, FORMER COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, MUMBAI



BHASKAR PAUL

FAWZAN HUSAIN



“ MUMBAI IS ONE OF INDIA'S NERVE-CENTRES. WE MUST ADD VALUE TO IT AND TO OUR LIVES, NOT DEplete IT OF ENERGY. ”

TANUJA CHANDRA, FILMMAKER

For a segment of society, Raj Thackeray is perhaps an alternative they've so far not had. While Jet Airways employees approaching the MNS after they were sacked is the most prominent example, several others have sought help from the party. When Bandra's New English School asked its students to pay their annual fees at one go, the parents approached local MNS leaders for help and launched a signature campaign to pressure the management. The decision has since been revoked. On grounds of anonymity, a mother of one student says: "The MNS leaders took up our cause and made the management take notice. Our voice would have gone unheard otherwise."

Small wonder, the Shiv Sena is looking rather foolish even as Raj projects himself as a saviour of the common men in its own backyard. While his methods are bordering on criminal, the public response suggests that there are as many Maharashtrians disgusted with his strong-arm tactics as there are those who may silently sympathise. However, with job fears becoming an emotive issue, his strategy may be politically viable if constitutionally wrong. Raut acknowledges that Raj has the power to damage other parties in the state, including the Sena. "Each time a new party comes into being, it does eat into the votes of the existing parties. About 10-12 of our seats will be affected, but the maximum damage will be to others." Ask him if a section of the party regrets losing Raj, and the answer is, "Yes, but I cannot comment on that."

Like almost any crises in recent times, the conflict in Maharashtra has the potential of triggering off a bigger and more dangerous confrontation that will pit Indians against fellow Indians. The unlikely coming together of Bihar's worst political foes has already prompted the state's people to counter violence with violence in what promises to be a tit-for-tat battle. Lalu's threat to suspend trains in states where rail passengers have been attacked and Amar Singh's pledge to send Samajwadi Party workers to protect non-Maharashtrians in Mumbai is a clear sign that the political stakes are being raised and could trigger a full scale conflagration. For India, there would be no greater tragedy than to allow a mere rabble-rouser to orchestrate such a situation.

**with Farzand Ahmed in Patna and
Subhash Mishra in Lucknow**

COUNTER ATTACK: Protesters in Patna disrupt rail services



RAJAN RAHI